

Greetings from Rev. Prof. Fr Ioan Sauca,
Interim General Secretary of the World Council of Churches, Geneva,
to Dr Abuzar Ebrahimi Torkaman,
Head of the Islamic Culture and Relations Organisation, Tehran,
and to Dr Mohammad Mahdi Tashkiri,
Director General of the Center for Interreligious and Intercultural Dialogue, Tehran

27 October, 2020

Dr Ebrahimi, Dr Tashkiri,

On behalf of the World Council of Churches, it is a privilege to greet you on this significant occasion as we thank God for 25 years of Muslim-Christian dialogue between the Center for Interreligious and Intercultural Dialogue and the World Council of Churches.

We were very sorry that, due to the pandemic, it was impossible to hold the meeting here in Switzerland which we had planned with you for September 2020. God willing, that meeting will happen when it is wise for us to gather again in person, and we look forward to welcoming your delegation when that is possible. However, we cannot let this important anniversary pass without speaking to you directly. Please allow me to assure you of our continuing commitment to this process of dialogue and to thank you for all that you have done on your side to sustain it, so that it can bear the good fruit of deepened understanding and respect between the communities that we represent.

I wish here to acknowledge the important contribution made to our dialogue by the late Ayatollah Sheikh Mohammad Ali Tashkiri, who died recently. We are grateful for his dedication to this cause and offer our sympathies to his family and his colleagues.

We are also deeply grateful for the contribution to our dialogue of our member churches in Iran. As we pray for the flourishing of the formal dialogue process between our offices, we recognize the importance of dialogue both at this level and, at the level of everyday life, between Muslims and Christians in Iran.

The growth of interreligious dialogue is one of the most encouraging developments of recent times. However, although dialogue between Muslims and Christians can bring many blessings, we cannot suggest that it is always easy. Those who participate in dialogue must be willing to listen with humility and attentiveness as well as speaking clearly and confidently from the perspective of their own faith; to reflect with a spirit of healthy self-criticism, and to try to see reality as their partners in dialogue understand it. There will also always be points of disagreement between Muslims and Christians, which dialogue should not aim to hide; rather, we should learn to disagree well, with intelligence and respect. Through dialogue we can also identify those areas where we firmly agree with each other and can work together for justice, peace and the flourishing of God's good creation. So let us pray for God's continuing blessing on this dialogue, with gratitude for all that has been achieved in the last 25 years and looking forward confidently to further good developments as we plan our next meeting.

One of the most precious gifts we can receive through interreligious dialogue is a sense of solidarity across the boundaries between our different communities, cultures and societies. Especially in the early months of the pandemic, we were deeply aware of the suffering of the people of Iran, due both to the rapid spread of the COVID-19 virus and to the crippling effect of sanctions. This prompted the WCC, together with other Christian organisations, to urge the President of the USA to lift those sanctions. ‘Serving a Wounded World in Interreligious Solidarity’ is also the theme of our very recent publication, together with the Pontifical Council for Interreligious Dialogue, which we have been glad to share with you. I hope that we will increasingly find ways to work together in solidarity for the good of our wider world.

FR IOAN SAUCA